

IMPACT REPORT

COOL/SCA AI IMPACT

Denver Summit · 2025



FROM THE ORGANIZING TEAM

Hello,

Welcome to the Denver Cool/Scary AI Impact Summit report. As the organizing team, we are thrilled to share highlights from this inaugural event. The vision is to democratize the conversation around artificial intelligence — asking what if seven billion people were helping to direct where AI is going instead of five billionaires in Silicon Valley?

The summit brought together thought leaders, educators and practitioners from across nonprofits, foundations, companies and civil society, each doing innovative work with AI for social good.

As humans and innovators in the social impact space, we cannot ignore the gnarly perils of AI. The environmental footprint of countless GPUs humming away — energy, water, community displacement — is unmistakable and must be addressed. Dystopian possibilities for the labor force and for human relationships are very real and must be understood to mitigate the worst outcomes.

And we believe that as innovators for social good, we cannot stand aside focused uniformly on these wrongs and fail to harness the potential of AI to help solve some of our most pressing social problems. Our goal was to embrace these contradictions.

In short, the summit's significance lay in forging a community intent on harnessing AI for good. It underscored that we must proactively shape AI's development to serve humanity, rather than simply react to it.

Onward,

Jen, Peter, and Ted

Denver Summit 2025 Organizing Team



FROM FEAR TO FRONTIER

One resounding theme was the need for nonprofits to move from AI anxiety to AI action. Many organizations still feel trepidation, yet as one speaker put it, the train is here and it is not going to stop.

Gurpreit Juneja of STACK Infrastructure shared an anecdote from a nonprofit CEO who admitted she was terrified of AI — but soon realized she was more terrified of being left behind. Six months later she reported a pilot that cut a once-onerous grant reporting process from three days to three hours, a 95% reduction with zero new staff. AI had shifted from a threat to a mission multiplier.

Start small, prove value

Experts advised beginning with modest, focused projects that demonstrate quick wins — piloting one workflow with no big budget commitment. Often a handful of staff succeeding is what moves a skeptical leader. In a sector where everyone is over-stretched, the mindset shift matters: AI adoption is not a

MAIN TAKEAWAY

AI's future is in our hands. While AI will disrupt jobs, industries and society, it also offers unprecedented opportunity — if we intentionally guide it. Rather than fear an AI takeover, we should focus on becoming AI-enabled humans.

**"AI isn't going to steal your job,
but a person who knows how to
effectively use AI could steal your job."**

SEAN GANNON · GTMPL



CONTRADICTIONS AND PATTERNS

CONTRADICTIONS

Inclusivity vs. tech elitism

Even as AI is driven by big tech, this event championed a grassroots approach. How do we involve all seven billion of us when so much power is concentrated among a few?

Innovation vs. regulation

One founder described well-intended consumer legislation that could do a lot wrong and hurt small innovators doing social good. We need guardrails, yet overzealous rules might stifle helpful tools.

Hype vs. reality

Even as AI astonishes with human-like feats, it still has obvious flaws — a cutting-edge image generator makes beautiful art but struggles to draw hands. What can AI truly do today?

Efficiency vs. empathy

Leaders are excited by automation and instant analysis, and equally worried about losing the human touch. Technology must complement, not replace, our empathy and ethics.

PATTERNS

Empowerment and access

Anyone can now download a model and experiment — power once locked in labs is available to the everyday person. The fact that you attended means you have a seat at the table.

Human–AI synergy

AI was framed as augmenting human capability, not replacing it. The best systems route to humans faster, doing the grunt work so people can focus on judgment, creativity and empathy.

Breakneck pace, playful learning

New tools every day. Speakers encouraged a playful, experimental mindset — from art to chatbots, hands-on play proved the best teacher and demystified AI.

Ethics and responsibility

From data privacy and bias to impacts on jobs and mental health, the community agreed that societal implications must be considered up front, not as an afterthought.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS

We heard from a lineup of speakers each linking technology with social impact in their own way. Here are highlights from a selection of them.

Daniel Ritchie

FOUNDER, BRAINWAVE COLLECTIVE

Kicked off the day with “WTF is AI?” — an accessible tour of AI’s history and current landscape. Daniel explained how modern AI works (lots of math and tiny decisions at massive scale) and gave context for the recent explosion of capabilities. Crucially, he reminded us that we get to decide how these things are implemented. His call to action: every sector should leave its imprint on AI’s future and ask the hard questions — why is this being built, and who is doing it?

Jen Hanson

AI PRODUCT CONSULTANT

Shared a playful path to AI literacy. Jen spoke to those who feel overwhelmed, arguing that learning this technology can be fun, creative and accessible. A self-proclaimed math and astronomy nerd, she started with art — using image generators for playful projects and picking up the basics through curiosity. Her key takeaway: you do not need to be an expert to begin, and childlike curiosity can spark understanding for the AI-curious people in our lives.

Kelly Kinnebrew, PhD

FOUNDER, MINERVACOACH

A clinical psychologist turned entrepreneur introduced Minerva, an AI coach that listens during meetings to help people improve soft skills like active listening — a digital nudge to take a breath and really hear your team. She framed it as a social good: better listeners make better leaders. She also shared a cautionary tale, having testified against a well-intentioned Colorado AI bill that tries to protect but does a lot wrong and could hurt small innovators.



SESSION HIGHLIGHTS, CONTINUED

Sean Gannon

FOUNDER, GTMPL

Spoke on going beyond hyper-personalization in ed-tech and sales. In just a few years he went from asking what AI even was to using it daily with his teams. He showed how teams can use AI responsibly for outreach, lead qualification and content creation, emphasizing training people not just to use AI but to use it ethically and effectively. His advice: do not fear AI taking over — learn it and leverage it.

Peter Genuardi

CEO, SEE THE STARS

Introduced the concept of an intelligence safety net. Peter painted an urgent picture: due to policy changes, millions of Americans will lose SNAP benefits and Medicaid coverage — a tsunami of need that traditional systems are not prepared for. His project uses AI and direct-response outreach to find at-risk families and connect them with support services quickly, coordinating aid in ways government alone cannot.

Maya

FOUNDER, BATTLEGROUND AI

Explored how AI can help navigate public policy. 2025 was a huge year for legislation — over 135,000 bills introduced across the U.S., including more than a thousand related to AI. Her startup crunches legislative text and advertising data to flag policy changes and compliance issues in real time. With bills appearing every four minutes on average, nonprofits can stay informed and respond. Her key insight: marry AI's speed with human context, so people still decide how to act.



WHAT DENVER DOES NEXT

Implications and action steps for Denver's nonprofit sector.

Invest in capacity and culture

Boards and funders should treat AI readiness as a critical capacity issue, not a luxury — resourcing AI literacy training and a culture of continuous learning. Low-stakes workshops, hackathons and sandbox projects let staff experiment on work relevant to their jobs. Leadership sets the tone that ethical experimentation is encouraged; early adopters become internal champions.

Embed ethics and inclusion from day one

Establish guidelines addressing bias, privacy and transparency before deploying. Ensure datasets represent the communities you serve, be open about where AI is used in your programs, and create feedback channels so clients and staff can raise concerns. Good technology coming under the microscope is welcome — lead by example.

Leverage the local AI-for-good ecosystem

No nonprofit needs to tackle AI alone. The Denver region has a growing tech-for-good community — a local AI meetup with over three thousand members and numerous subgroups, including an active Women in AI circle. Plug into these networks, partner with companies and universities, and share talent or tools.

Engage in the policy dialogue

With AI legislation surging at state and federal levels, data governance, digital infrastructure funding and labor displacement will all be on the table. Given Colorado's legislative pace, being proactive is essential. Now is the time to push for an AI future that is accountable, inclusive and geared toward solving human problems.



WITH THANKS

THANK YOU TO OUR COMMUNITY HOSTS



SEE THE STARS



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COOL/SCARY AI

A national series of community-centered
conversations about AI's real impact,
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coolslashscary.ai
ben@coolslashscary.ai

